Superman in the Nursing Home/Dear Superman

By Rusty Russell and Ron Koertge

INTRODUCTION

Superhuman strength. Invulnerability. Motivation to defend the world from evildoers. A secret identity. AND the ability to look good in long underwear. These are the traits that define the true superhero: Batman, Captain America, Captain Marvel, Spider-Man (gradually look up into the sky during this phrase, then point and get really excited . . . .) Faster than a speeding bullet! More powerful than a locomotive! Able to leap tall buildings in a single bound! LOOK! Up In The Sky! It's a bird! It's a plane! It's SUPERMAN!

How serious a subject matter is Superman? Serious enough for poetry to be based on him. Today I want you to meet the man inside the super hero: Clark Kent or Superman in the Nursing Home by Rusty Russell

Superman in the Nursing Home

It started with the flying.

I just had to get away.

I thought I was going crazy, hearing things –

voices, sirens, water running behind walls,

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and the crying, someone always crying behind closed doors.

It was that super hearing. I had it then.

So some nights I'd fly out of the city

until I couldn't hear them anymore,

way out over the ocean where I could see the earth turning

and the sun rising over the edge of the next day.

Miraculous, made me feel like the only man on earth,

but I wasn't a man. I was a freak.

Then came all those years

of changing clothes in dirty phone booths;

chewing gum on the floor getting stuck in my pants,

cigarette butts, and the smell of winos and urine.

Sometimes the phone would ring while I was in there

and it always gave me the creeps.

Think about it – an anonymous telephone

in the middle of the night on a deserted street

and it's ringing for someone. Anyone.

I never picked it up. I didn't want to hear it –

lives pulled thin over a phone wire,

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stories of pockets with holes,
bad breath whistling through bad teeth.
What could I do?
Someone sobbing and sloppy drunk in a bar somewhere
picks up a phone, dials a number at random
and gets Superman
with his pants down in a phone booth.

Believe it or not, this Superman thing started out
modestly:
no cape, no tights.
Just lifting automobiles off trapped motorists,
or catching falling babies before they hit the sidewalk.
But it felt so good, the applause,
the way the Earth girls looked at me,
and it all got out of hand.
I should have stopped after the first bank robbery.
There would never be any cash reward in this
for an indestructible guy like me.
Just "Thanks, Superman,"
and the bankers smiling as I flew away.

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All the time they were thinking,
"What a ***** tool," and they were right.
Hell, it was all insured.
If I'd quit then and done something with myself –
forgotten this superhero thing and gotten a realtor's
license
or just a full time job with benefits,
maybe I wouldn't be waiting for the TV hour
here in the dayroom of the County Home.
I never saved anyone from this. No one could.

But in a way, it's true, what they say,
that every moment lasts forever,
because I still dream about those first nights
when I was young, before it all started,
flying out of Metropolis in my pajamas
with the moon overhead and the silver ocean below,
and the billboards left behind
like a cry for help I can finally ignore.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Rusty Russell
Book: Poetry Slam: The Competitive Art of Performance Poetry (ed Gary Mex Glazner)
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AWARD HISTORY

2006 National Qualifier

TRANSITION

And as if this pitiful reverie wasn't enough . . . Superman has problems with women to . . . . In fact, and he'll hate me for sharing this . . . he just got this letter from his wife Lois yesterday. Dear Superman by Lois Lane (aka Ron Koertge)

Dear Superman

Dear Superman,
I know you think that things
will always be the same: I'll rinse
out your tights, kiss you good-bye
at the window, and every few weeks
get kidnapped by some stellar goons.

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But I'm not getting any younger,
and you're not getting any older.
Pretty soon I'll be too frail
to take aloft, and with all those
nick-of-time rescues, you're bound
to pick up somebody more tender
and just as ga-ga as I used to be.
I'd hate her for being 17 and you
for being… what, 700?
I can see your sweet face as you read
this, and I know you'd like to siphon
off some strength for me, even if it
meant you could only leap small buildings
at a single bound. But you can't,
and, anyway, would I want to
just stand there while everything
else rushed past?
Take care of yourself and of the world
which is your own true love. One day
soon, as you patrol the curved earth,
that'll be me down there tucked in

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for good, being what you'll never be

but still

Your friend,

Lois Lane

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Ron Koertge
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CLOSING

SAID WISTFULLY, SADLY: Faster than a speeding bullet? More powerful than a locomotive?! Able to leap tall buildings in a single bound! LOOK! Up In The Sky! It's a bird! It's a plane! It's SUPERMAN!

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